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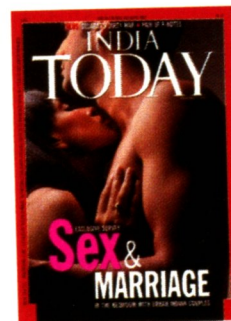
The other day I went to a show in Delhi featuring an NRI stand-up comic where the hall of 2,000 was overflowing with mainly young men and women. This comic launched into graphic descriptions of all kinds of sexual acts with actions to match and his language was sprinkled liberally with four-letter words, both in Hindi and English. How this act passed our prissy censors is beyond me but I expected some people to walk out as the show, though funny, was just plain vulgar. Nothing of the sort happened. Everyone laughed and cheered for more. It then occurred to me that there is a whole new world of sexuality out there. Look around and you will see changes. Couples locked in embraces on park benches, walking the streets holding hands, extensive coverage about sex in the media and even TV soaps incorporating sexual issues into their storylines. Sex is definitely out of the closet in urban India.

Six years ago, we decided to explore Indian attitudes to sex and set about establishing an annual survey which sought to uncover the changes taking place in the personal lives of Indians. The sex survey, conducted in partnership with AC Nielsen-ORG MARG, has so far reached out to men and women, single and married people, teenagers and fortysomethings. In this, the sixth INDIA TODAY sex survey we decided to dig even deeper into the darker corners of sexual behaviour. This year's survey deals with the taboos that form part of the secret lives of Indians.

We identified seven such taboos and tried to tap India's opinion on them. They are kinky sex, homosexuality, adultery, incest, sex below the age of consent, prostitution and pornography. The 2008 India Today AC Nielsen-ORG MARG sex survey on these controversial subjects is our largest, with a sample size of 5,353 men and women between the ages of 18 and 40 in 10 cities.

The results were somewhat startling: Everything that was thought to be taboo is slowly breaking down. While 16 per cent of the men admit to having had sex with other men, 19 per cent say they have had sex with women prostitutes, while 38 per cent say they have no problems with having sex with women below 18. Pornography is widely used, and not only by men. Women have emerged as big viewers of virtual porn, with one in four saying they have seen porn at one time or the other. Our respondents were far more open about unusual sexual practices than in previous surveys. After the results from this year's survey came in, we asked leading sociologists in India and overseas to analyse them in greater depth and identify emerging trends, so the wealth of data could be understood more comprehensively.

India has always thought of itself as a socially and sexually conservative country. But successive sex reports have revealed a slow shifting of attitudes in all directions. This year's survey shows that there is both a more adventurous and a darker side to India's quiet sexual revolution.



**OUR NOVEMBER
2007 COVER**


(Aroon Purie)